

Carta en cifra de Venecia

A ducal dispatch from the Senate of Venice to Giovanni Mocenigo, its ambassador at the court of Henri III, with the enclosed reply given to Girolamo Gondi, the king's envoy, who had come to ask for aid and a league. Read with the Republic's own surviving key, *Ziffra prima*.

What the letter says

Gondi reached Venice by 15 April 1589. Henri III, at war with the Catholic League since the Guise murders of December 1588, wanted subsidies, a defensive alliance, and help recovering the marquisate of Saluzzo, which the Duke of Savoy had seized the previous autumn. Venice answered warmly and gave nothing: its own circumstances forbade aid for now, but it would press the pope once more on the king's behalf, as it had over Saluzzo.

The covering dispatch tells Mocenigo how to explain that answer if the French raise it, and complains that his letters are being intercepted on the Lyon road: only four lines of his letter of 28 March had arrived. He is to find a safer route.

How it was read

The seven cipher pages use a nomenclator of letters with superscript numbers (d15 is one group) standing for letters, syllables, words, titles, numerals and nulls. The archival key DECODE R1789, from the Archivio di Stato di Venezia, decodes all of it. Transcription and reading were made in September 2026 by native Codex agents from the public BNE photographs, checked against the key, and reviewed independently the same day. Everything is reproducible from the published files.

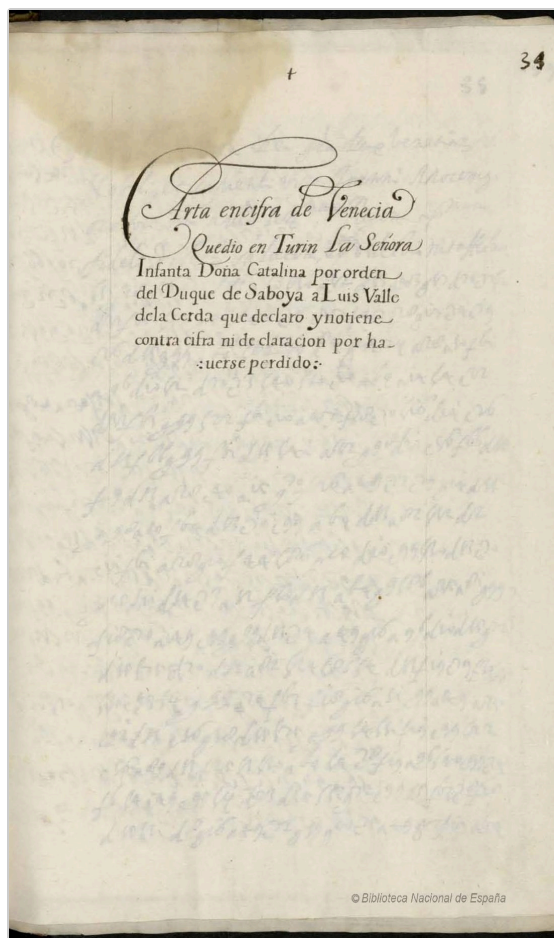
The letter was broken once before

The title page of the volume, in a Spanish archival hand, says this cipher letter from Venice was handed over in Turin by the Infanta Catalina Micaela, Duchess of Savoy, on her husband's orders, to Luis Valle de la Cerda, Philip II's cipher secretary, who deciphered it, and that both key and decipherment were lost.

So the dispatch that complains of interception was itself intercepted, in the state whose duke held Saluzzo, and read by the best cryptanalyst in Spanish service. The pages below recover, with the key he never had, what he worked out without it.

Reading the columns

Left: the BNE photograph of each page (click to enlarge). Middle: the Italian in lightly modernised spelling, with Latin and clear-hand passages labelled. Right: an English translation. Square brackets mark text that is doubtful, restored under the binding, or repaired where the clerk slipped; [...] is unread. Each page's notes say where readings are conjectural, and a fold-out table gives the cipher groups line by line with the key's raw output.



ITALIAN

SPANISH, ARCHIVAL HAND

Carta en cifra de Venecia. Que dio en Turín la Señora Infanta Doña Catalina, por orden del Duque de Saboya, a Luis Valle de la Cerda, que declaró; y no tiene contracifra ni declaración por haverse perdido.

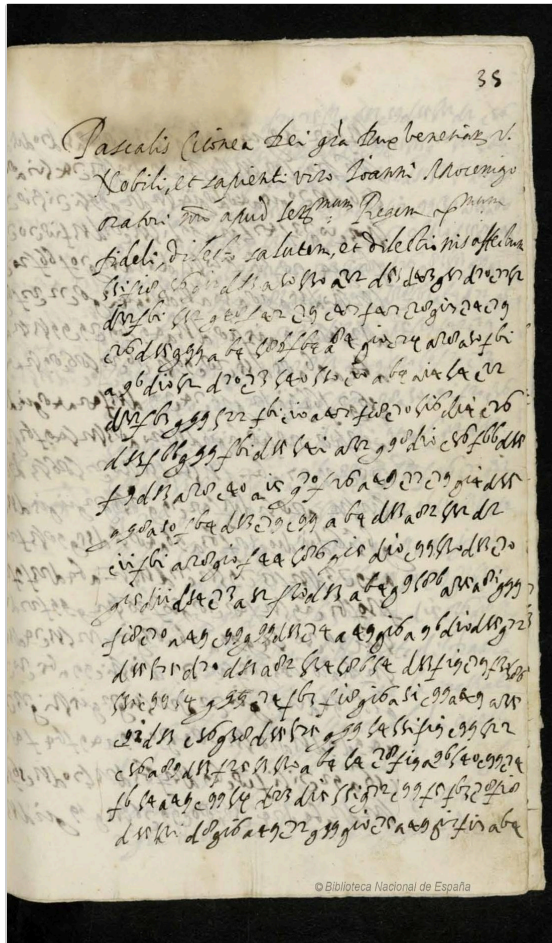
ENGLISH

TRANSLATION

Letter in cipher from Venice. Which the Lady Infanta Doña Catalina gave in Turin, by order of the Duke of Savoy, to Luis Valle de la Cerda, who deciphered it; and it has neither key nor decipherment, these having been lost.

NOTES

- The Infanta is Catalina Micaela (1567–1597), daughter of Philip II and wife of Charles Emmanuel I of Savoy. Luis Valle de la Cerda (c. 1559–1607) was Philip II's principal codebreaker and later cipher secretary at court.
- *Declaró* is the period term for deciphering; *contracifra* is the key. The note therefore says the dispatch was broken in 1589 and that the working was later lost. The reading on the following pages recovers, with the surviving Venetian key, what Valle de la Cerda read without one.
- Savoy had seized the marquisate of Saluzzo from France in late 1588. The letter that passed through Savoyard hands discusses helping France recover it.



f. 35r · Biblioteca Nacional de España, Mss/994

ITALIAN

LATIN, CLEAR HAND

Pascalis Ciconea, Dei gratia Dux Venetiarum etc., nobili et sapienti viro Joanni Mocenigo, oratori nostro apud Serenissimum Regem Christianissimum, fideli dilecto, salutem et dilectionis affectum.

CIPHER, LINES 1–17

Vegnù in questa città [fin] 15 del mese presente, vi [ricevemmo] il signor Gerolamo Gondi, et il [...] quale che ci espose delli travagli et bisogni presenti di Sua Maestà Cristianissima. Egli così nella sua prima audientia come dopo in un'altra che ebbe da noi, commemorandoci l'amor et affetione grande che quel Serenissimo re porta alla repubblica nostra, et quanto confidi nella cordiale corrispondente del affettuoso animo suo verso di lei, ne ricercò con molta instantia di sovvenirle in tanta necessità et somministrarle alcun soccorso per resistere all'imminente pericolo di quella corona, et ...

ENGLISH

SALUTATION

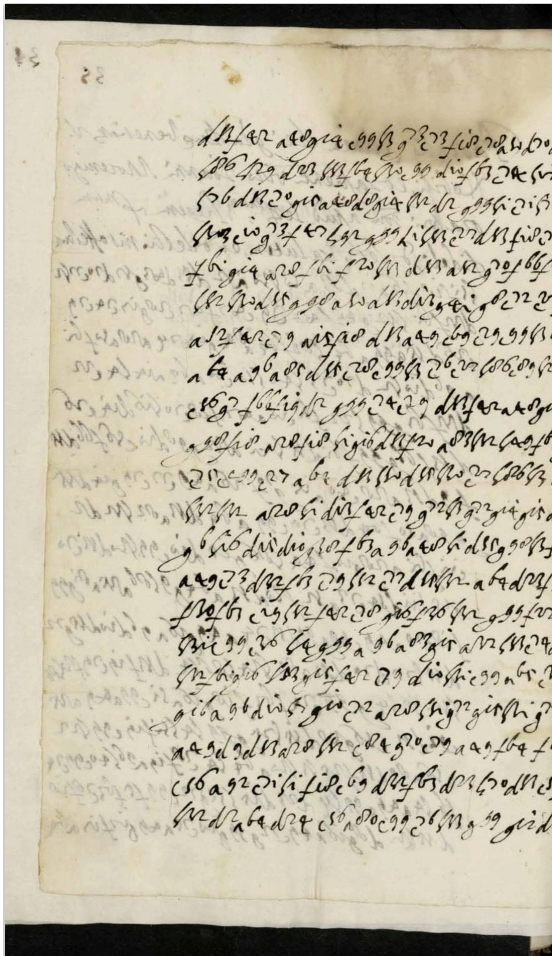
Pasquale Cicogna, by the grace of God Doge of Venice etc., to the noble and wise Giovanni Mocenigo, our ambassador to the Most Serene and Most Christian King, our faithful and beloved: greeting and the affection of our love.

CIPHER, LINES 1–17

Having come to this city [by] the fifteenth of the present month, Signor Gerolamo Gondi was [received] by us, and he set out to us the troubles and present needs of His Most Christian Majesty. Both at his first audience and afterward at another that he had with us, reminding us of the great love and affection that the Most Serene King bears our Republic, and of how much he trusts in the cordial reciprocation of his affectionate feelings toward it, he asked us with great insistence to assist him in such great need and to furnish some relief to withstand the imminent danger to that crown, and ...

NOTES

- The literal key output for the reception verb is *recessimo*; *ricevemmo* is an editorial repair. *Fen* is read as *fin*.
- After *et il* there is one extra group (a84 or a94) that no reading absorbs; *il quale* suppresses it.
- Gondi's first audience: he had reached Venice by 15 April. The date d43 g57 = 15 is read directly.



f. 35v · Biblioteca Nacional de España, Mss/994

ITALIAN

CIPHER, LINES 1–21 · RIGHT EDGE LOST IN THE GUTTER

... assicurarsi dalli nemici del[la cor]ona, voltar poi le sue forze alla
recuperatione di Saluzzo, [tol]togli dal signor [duca] di Savoia
nella [gu]erra che è nota a cadauno; [in]vitandoci appresso, che lo
[giudi]cassimo bene, a collegarsi [...] et stringersi maggio[r]mente
se[co] in qualche unione di lega, assicura[ndo]ne che ne [sa]riano
fatti tutti [quelli] larghi et avvantaggiosi [par]titi che [si] potessimo
desiderare.

[Alla] qual sua proposta, iscusandosi no[i] con li presenti
movimenti et per altri nostri gravissimi rispetti di non [po]ter[gli]
soddisfare come volentieri vorressimo poter far, [abbia]mo
risposto quello che vederete dalla copia che vi mandiamo col [...]
[inclusa] nelle presenti per vostra in[forma]tione; et perché,
informato di questa ...

ENGLISH

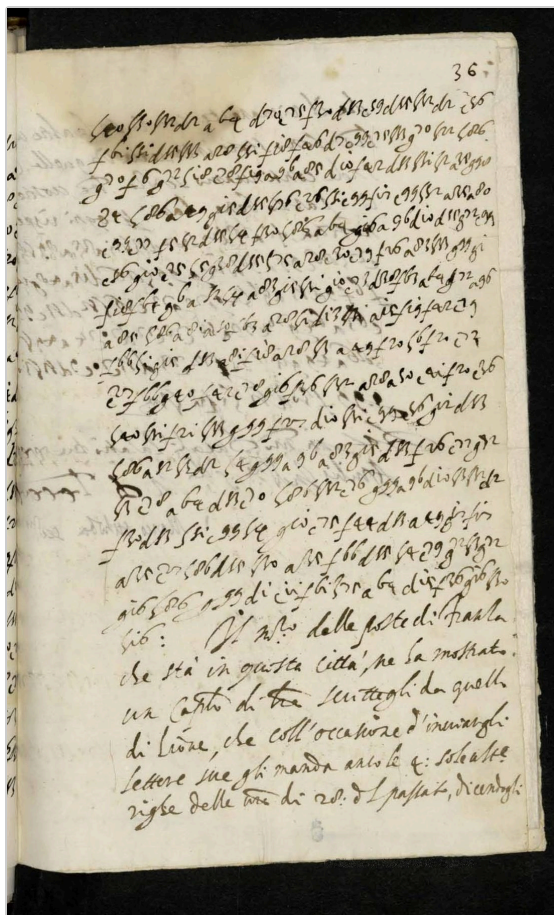
CIPHER, LINES 1–21

... to secure himself against the enemies of [the crown], and then
to turn his forces to the recovery of Saluzzo, [taken] from him by
the [Duke] of Savoy in the war that is known to everyone; inviting
us moreover, if we [judged] it well, to ally ourselves [...] and to bind
ourselves more closely with him in some form of league, assuring
us that all the [most] generous and advantageous terms that we
could desire would be granted us.

[To] this proposal of his, we excused ourselves, on account of the
present disturbances and other very weighty considerations of
ours, from being able to satisfy [him] as willingly as we would wish
to be able to do, and [we have] answered what you will see from
the copy that we send you, [enclosed] in the present letter for your
information; and so that, informed of this ...

NOTES

- This is the verso of a leaf bound tight to the gutter: every line loses one to three groups at the right. Bracketed supplies here are conjectural restorations of hidden text, not readings.
- [la cor]ona, [tol]togli and [quelli] are proposals of this review; the published edition leaves those places open. The visible groups at the start of line 2 read *o n a*.
- Literal *tergo* (line 16) is kept in the transcription; [po]ter[gli] is a repair. In *inclusa* the second sign looks like the numeral 8 rather than c; the intended word is not in doubt.



f. 36r · Biblioteca Nacional de España, Mss/994

ITALIAN

CIPHER, LINES 1–16

... trattatione et della nostra intentione, in evento che ve ne sia parlato da Sua Maestà Cristianissima o da alcun de' suoi ministri, possiate in questa occorrenza governarvi conforme al senso nostro et risponder in quella sostanza che abbiamo noi fatto di qua. Nel qual caso farete quelli prudenti et destri officii che vi [parerà] benissimo usare, a fine che si conoscano li giustissimi rispetti che ci hanno intrattenuto di non poter in questa occasione soddisfare a noi medesimi et alla ottima dispositione nostra verso quella Serenissima corona, congiunta con un sommo desiderio di ogni grandezza et prosperità.

CLEAR HAND

Il mastro delle poste di Francia che sta in questa città ne ha mostrato un capitolo di lettere scrittogli da quello di Lione, che coll'occasione d'invargli lettere sue gli manda anco le 4 sole ult[im]e righe delle vostre di 28 del passato, dicendogli ...

ENGLISH

CIPHER, LINES 1–16

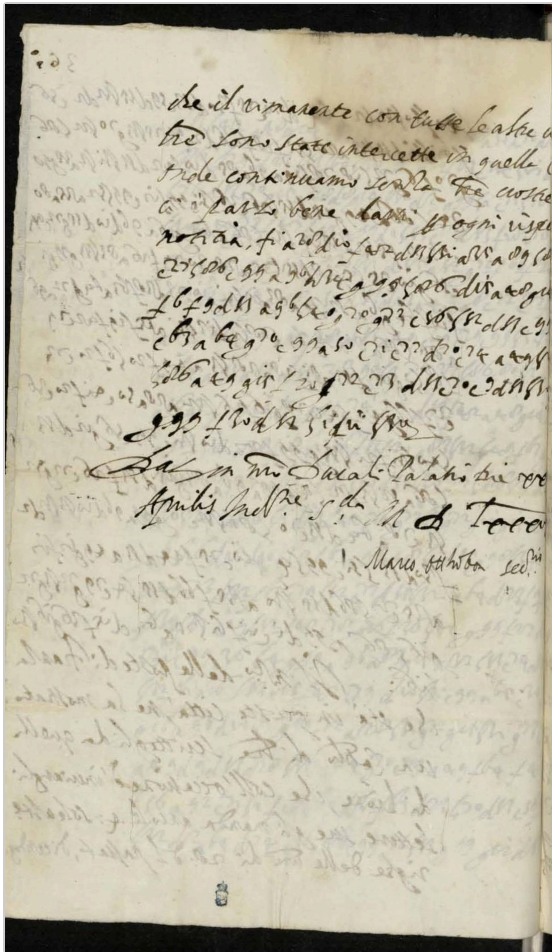
... negotiation and of our intention, if His Most Christian Majesty or any of his ministers should speak to you of it, you may on that occasion govern yourself according to our sense and answer in the same substance as we have done here. In which case you will perform those prudent and skilful offices that you [judge] best to use, so that the most just considerations may be understood which have held us back from being able, on this occasion, to satisfy ourselves and our excellent disposition toward that Most Serene crown, joined with a supreme desire for its every greatness and prosperity.

CLEAR HAND

The French postmaster who resides in this city has shown us an extract from letters written to him by his counterpart in Lyon, who, on the occasion of forwarding letters of his own, also sends him the only four [last] lines of yours of the 28th of last month, telling him ...

NOTES

- Two blotted groups precede *benissimo* on line 8; [parerà] is supplied for sense.
- Ult[im]e is a correction of this review: the manuscript has *ult^e* with an abbreviation mark, where the published edition read *altre*. The sense is that only the last four lines of Mocenigo's letter of 28 March survived.
- The text goes into clear here and stays clear across the page turn; the postal complaint was evidently not considered secret.



f. 36v · Biblioteca Nacional de España, Mss/994

ITALIAN

CLEAR HAND

... che il rimanente con tutte le altre vostre sono state intercette in quelle strade. Continuiamo senza vostre, costretti a star bene [...] d'ogni vostra notitia;

CIPHER, LINES 1–6

acciò che possiate con tant[o mag]gior stu[di]o procura[r] una strada per inviar lettere et darci lume delle co[se che] occorrono lì alla giorna[ta]. Di nostra [se...ta].

FOOTER, CLEAR HAND

Dat. in nostro Ducali Palatio die XX[VII] Aprilis, Indictione 2^{da}.
Marco Ottobon, secretarioio.

ENGLISH

CLEAR HAND

... that the remainder, with all your other letters, have been intercepted on those roads. We continue without letters from you, forced to remain quite [...] of any news of you;

CIPHER, LINES 1–6

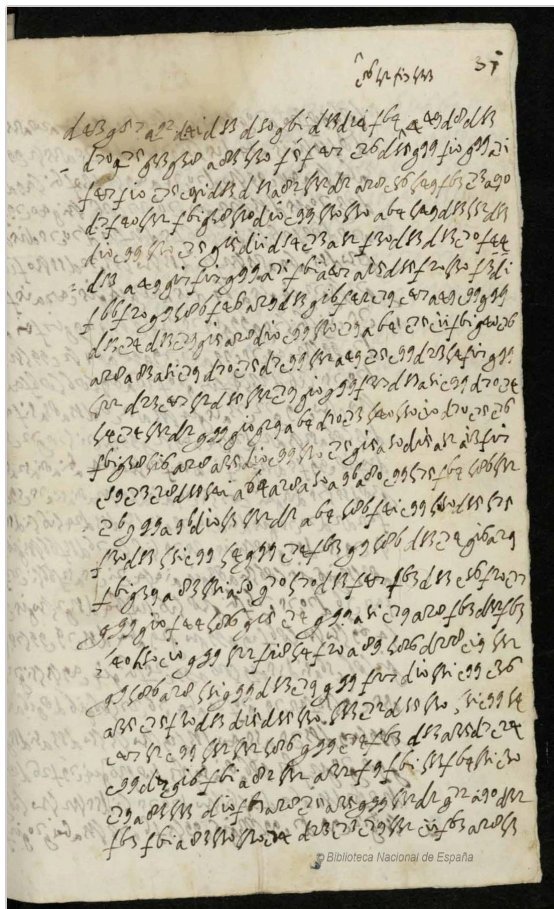
so that you may, with all the greater diligence, procure a route for sending letters and giving us light on the things that happen there from day to day. [Closing formula unresolved.]

FOOTER

Given in our Ducal Palace on the 2[7]th day of April, second indiction. Marco Ottobon, secretary.

NOTES

- The clear-hand word after *star bene* resists reading; the published edition offers *scarsi*?. Something like *privi* or *digiuni* (deprived, starved of news) would fit the idiom, but the ink does not clearly support either.
- The last cipher line reads *di nostra* followed by two doubtful groups and *ta*. *Secreta* has been suggested; it is not established.
- The day is cut by the gutter after *xx*; 27 comes from the catalogue date. The indiction is independently right: 1589 falls in indiction 2.
- Above the subscription a large scrawl in a different ink, possibly a Spanish archival mark, runs into the gutter.



f. 37r · Biblioteca Nacional de España, Mss/994

ITALIAN

CIPHER, LINES 1–24

1589, a 24 aprile. Copia della risposta fatta al signor Gondi, ambasciatore di Francia.

Signor ambasciatore, la molta affetione che in tutti li tempi passati è stata portata et tuttavia porta la repubblica nostra alla Serenissima corona di Francia è così ben nota ad ognuno, quanto sia chiarissimo il cordiale amore che portiamo et la grande stima che facciamo della particular persona di Sua Maestà Cristianissima; per il [che] sentiamo quel dispiacere delle sol[lev]atione di quel regno et delli travagli della Maestà sua che comporta la reciproca buona intelligentia, et che ci sforza l'ottima dispositione et osservantia nostra verso di lei.

Quanto alle richieste fatteci da Vostra Signoria in nome di quel Serenissimo re, le diciamo che li travagli di Sua Maestà Cristianissima ne sono tanto più gravi quanto che vediamo di non poter ora, con la nostra pronta volontà verso il servizio di lei, accompagnar pari effetti come altre volte abbiamo fatto, [poiché] la conditione de' tempi l'è fatta tale per li motivi che si ...

ENGLISH

CIPHER, LINES 1–24

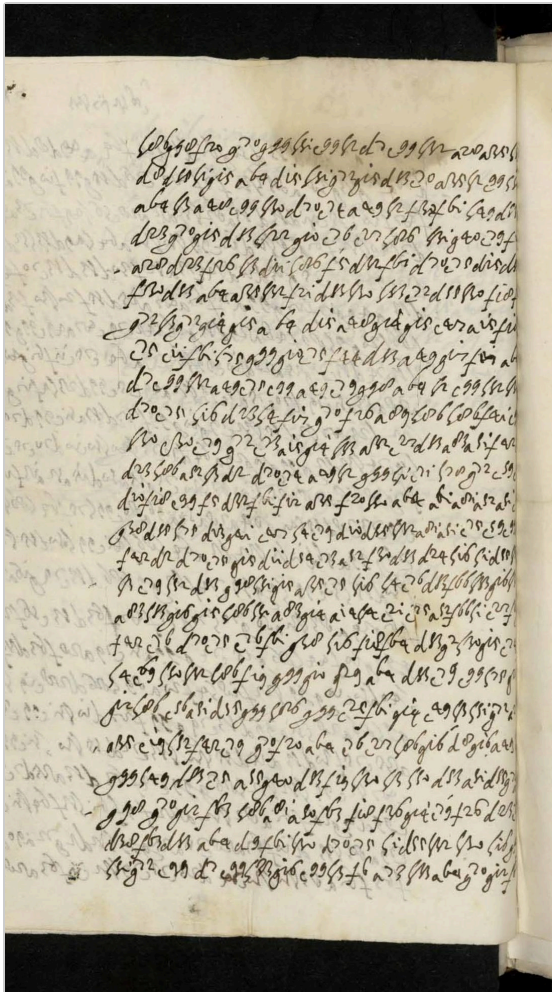
1589, 24 April. Copy of the reply made to Signor Gondi, ambassador of France.

Sir Ambassador, the great affection that our Republic has borne in all past times, and still bears, toward the Most Serene crown of France is as well known to everyone as it is entirely clear how heartfelt is the love we bear, and how great the esteem we have, for the particular person of His Most Christian Majesty; for which reason we feel that sorrow over the [uprisings] of that kingdom and the troubles of His Majesty which our mutual good understanding entails, and to which our excellent disposition and regard toward him compel us.

As to the requests made to us by Your Lordship in the name of that Most Serene King, we tell you that the troubles of His Most Christian Majesty weigh on us all the more heavily in that we see that we cannot at present, with our ready will toward his service, accompany it with corresponding deeds as we have done at other times, [since] the condition of the times has been made such, by the developments that are ...

NOTES

- Line 1 is the cleanest check of the key: d43 g57 a92 d41 gives 1 5 8 9 and d50 g61 gives 2 4, before *a-pri-l*.
- Line 11 encodes exactly *so-le-ti-one*. *Sol[lev]atione* assumes a skipped syllable by the clerk; the same word is spelled out in full on f. 37v.
- The key has a whole-word group for *tempo*, used here after *tutti li*; the reading prints *tempi*.



f. 37v · Biblioteca Nacional de España, Mss/994

ITALIAN

CIPHER, LINES 1–25 · RIGHT EDGE LOST IN THE GUTTER

... scrivono da diverse parti, che fa[nno] pensare et provvedere alla conser[vatione] et sicurtà delle cose nostre. Tutta[via], per dare a Sua Maestà Cristianissima quel maggio[r] testimo[nio] che per noi si può al presente della pro[nta] nostra et continuata volontà ne[l] desiderare et procurare il bene, la grandezza di quella Serenissima corona et particolar comodo et servi[tio] della sua persona, da noi tanto osser[va]ta, abbiamo deliberato, come già facessimo per occasione delle cose di Saluzzo, de interponer al presente ancor con nuova et efficace istanza presso il sommo pontefice la intercessione della repubblica nostra, perché Sua Santità si muova a dovere con la sua somma autorità favorire, ove farà bisogno, la causa giu[sti]ssima della Maestà sua nell'acquietare le sollevationi di quel regno et ammorzare questo incendio di guerra, il qual si vede con [certissimo] danno et maggiori pericoli di tutta la cristianità si va accendendo.

Da quei officii ne speriamo noi, per la prudentia et pietà della Santità sua, di veder partorirsi alcun frutto, et da quei ...

ENGLISH

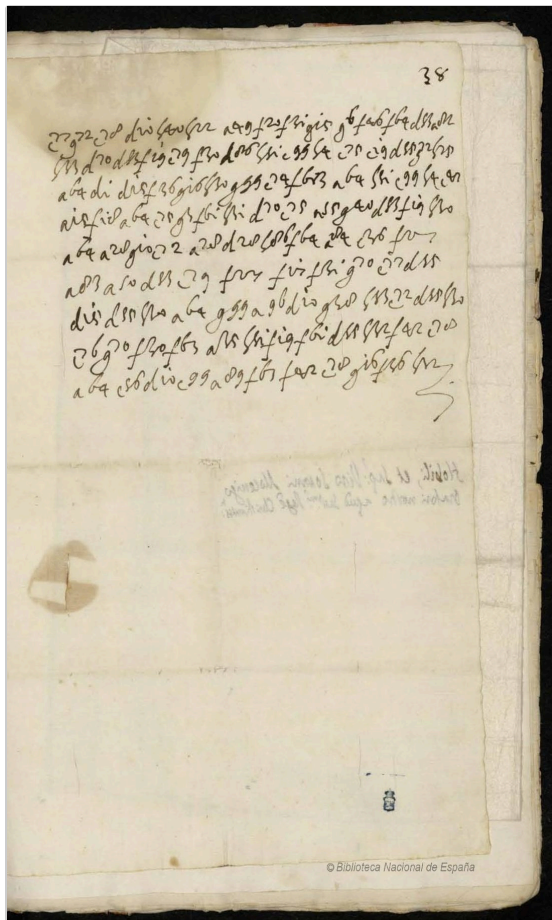
CIPHER, LINES 1–25

... reported from various quarters, which make us think of and provide for the preservation and security of our own affairs. Nevertheless, to give His Most Christian Majesty the greatest testimony that we can at present of our ready and continued will to desire and procure the good and the greatness of that Most Serene crown, and the particular benefit and service of his person, so greatly respected by us, we have resolved, as we already did on the occasion of the affairs of Saluzzo, to interpose once again, with a fresh and earnest instance before the Supreme Pontiff, the intercession of our Republic, so that His Holiness may be moved, as is fitting, to favour with his supreme authority, wherever there is need, the most just cause of His Majesty in quieting the uprisings of that kingdom and extinguishing this fire of war, which we see kindling with [certain] harm and greater dangers for all Christendom.

From those offices we hope, through the prudence and piety of His Holiness, to see some fruit brought forth; and from those ...

NOTES

- Three apparent clerk's errors are kept literal in the transcription and repaired here: *giussima* → *giu[sti]ssima*, *cirtissimo* → [certissimo], *inteponer* → *interponer*.
- Si movi a dovere* is the literal text; *si muova* modernises it.
- The earlier Venetian intercession over Saluzzo refers to the Republic's approach to Sixtus V after Savoy's seizure of the marquisate in the autumn of 1588.



f. 38r · Biblioteca Nacional de España, Mss/994

ITALIAN

CIPHER, LINES 1-9

... medesimi potrà Vostra Magnificentia conoscere qual sia la fede dell'animo nostro verso la grandezza et ogni prosperità di lei, et verso il bene et la quiete della cristianità; et che quello che più oltre ora non facciamo non nasce da men pronta et disposta volontà, ma da assai convenientissimi et importantissimi rispetti.

ADDRESS, INK OFFSET IN MIRROR IMAGE, LOWER RIGHT

Nobili et sapienti viro Joanni Mocenigo, oratori nostro apud Serenissimum Regem Christianissimum.

ENGLISH

CIPHER, LINES 1-9

... same [offices] Your Magnificence will be able to recognise the sincerity of our heart toward his greatness and every prosperity, and toward the good and the peace of Christendom; and that what we do not now do beyond this arises not from any less ready and willing disposition, but from very fitting and most weighty considerations.

ADDRESS

To the noble and wise Giovanni Mocenigo, our ambassador to the Most Serene and Most Christian King.

NOTES

- The last word's vowel is disputed (*importantissimi* or *importantissimi*); the intended word is not.
- The faint reversed writing below the cipher is the address from the outer leaf, transferred while the packet was folded. Read here from a mirrored enlargement; it matches the salutation on f. 35r.
- Cipher ends on line 9; the rest of the page is blank.

Sources

Manuscript: Biblioteca Nacional de España, Mss/994, *Memorial de los servicios prestados ... por D. Luis Valle de la Zerda; correspondencia y documentos del mismo*, ff. 34r–38r. Photographs from the Biblioteca Digital Hispánica, public-domain work, reproduction CC BY 4.0, credit Biblioteca Nacional de España. DECODE record R2252.

Key: Archivio di Stato di Venezia, B4 reg. 16 f. 64, *Ziffrà prima*, encoding and decoding tables, DECODE R1789. Consulted with the DECODE project's permission; its images are not reproduced. The letter was listed as undeciphered in Satoshi Tomokiyo's Unsolved Historical Ciphers.

Limits

This is a critical reading, not an every-sign diplomatic transcript. The versos (ff. 35v, 37v) lose their line endings in the gutter; a few groups are blotted; the clerk skipped or miskeyed a handful of syllables. Those places are bracketed above and listed in the notes. A registered copy in ASVe, Senato, Deliberazioni, Secreti, reg. 87 (April 1589) would settle them; none has been located online.

Transcription, key excerpt and decoder: github.com/aaymeloglu/unsolved-ciphers. Prepared 16 September 2026. No claim of publication priority is made.